maritime security challenges is further strengthened.

Any operation at sea is dependent on Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA). To develop a comprehensive MDA, the navy regularly patrols the far reaches of the IOR through Mission-Based Deployed ships, Boeing P8I maritime patrol aircraft/ Sea Guardian UAVs, and monitors it by satellites. It has set up coastal surveillance chains in the Seychelles, Mauritius, Maldives and Sri Lanka. The 'Information Fusion Centre for Indian Ocean Region' at Gurugram has established itself as a hub for MDA in the IOR by coordinating with over 20 countries and multinational constructs. Inputs are collated to develop a comprehensive MDA, which is shared with partners.

The reach of the navy has been extended through bilateral logistics treaties, operational turnaround facilities/ ports and building port infrastructure. The Indian Navy participates in over 20 bilateral and multilateral exercises each year. Our exercises with maritime powers have expanded over the years, and now involve complex multi-dimensional operations. The Malabar exercise with Quad partners is a prime example. In the Bay of Bengal, the navy carries out coordinated patrol of the maritime borders with Bangladesh, Myanmar, Thailand and Indonesia. It also carries out surveillance of the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) of the Maldives, Seychelles and Mauritius as they lack the capacity to patrol their large EEZ.

Training is another key aspect of our efforts. Every year, the navy provides structured training to over 900 foreign trainees. Hydrographic cooperation is another area of focus. Ships have conducted vital surveys for Myanmar, Mauritius and Sri Lanka. Lastly, the navy supports multilateral initiatives such as the Indian Ocean Naval Symposium (IONS) to enhance regional maritime security.

## THE GIANT STEPS

- **Our outlook and choices today will determine how India can harness its central position in the IOR, which puts us both at a strategic advantage and in the middle of a strategic churn**
- **Economic, diplomatic and military tools are likely to allow China to influence IOR sea lanes and jeopardise Indian interests. We need to bolster maritime security through capacity-building, capability-enhancement, cooperative engagement and collaborative effort**
- **The Navy needs a third aircraft carrier, more destroyers and frigates, nuclear-powered submarines and fleet support ships**

But all diplomatic initiatives need to be backed by hard power. If we are to be counted in the Indian Ocean, the nation needs to invest more in military capability, especially maritime capability. The navy needs additional blue water ships such as a third aircraft carrier with its air wing, more destroyers and frigates, nuclear-powered attack submarines (SSN) and fleet support ships (tankers) to be the first responder in the IOR.

As the nation rises to the high table of global affairs, India will be called upon to shoulder greater responsibilities in the IOR. The Indian Navy will have a significant role to play to ensure that the nation attains its rightful place in the world order through proactive and positive action. ■

*The author is a former Chief of Naval Staff*



*Illustration by* **SIDDHANT JUMDE**